

The Mysteries of Dholavira

(2600–1900 BCE)

The road to Dholavira cuts across a dazzling landscape of salty mudflats before entering Khadir Island. I'm travelling across to the island's western end, to the archaeological site of Dholavira, a nearly 5000-year-old city of the Harappan Civilization.

It is mid-afternoon in early April and the mercury is pushing 40°C. The pale hues of this desert land contrast with the colourful attires of women of various castes and semi-nomadic pastoral groups: Ahir, Meghwal, Rabari, Jat and others. I ask my taxi driver to stop for a photo, and a group of Ahir women receive me with curious stares and giggles, much as I recall from thirteen years ago in 2006, when I first visited Dholavira.

This is the Rann of Kutch, an area in north-western Gujarat comprising about a tenth of the state, bordering Pakistan. In prehistoric times, the Rann ('salt marsh') was a navigable extension of the Arabian Sea. It later got closed off from the sea by siltation and possibly also by seismic upheaval. Nowadays, during the monsoon, rain and seasonal rivers fill up the low-lying areas of the Rann, aka the 'white Rann', with water that turns brackish from the residual salt encrusted upon the ground. In some parts, the locals get out in boats and harvest shrimp. When the waters begin to dry up, flamingos migrate to its wetlands from northern climes.